

Animating Engagement: Connecting Technology, Artistry, and Purpose in a Small Public University

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Abstract

How do you spark engagement, technical learning, and creative growth among a diverse group of students, many of whom are first-generation college attendees? This talk highlights four high-impact projects that demonstrate how faculty can design inclusive, interdisciplinary experiences that connect to broader mediums and collaborations. Developed within a small public university animation program, serving a significant population of first-generation undergraduate students, these projects support learners who may not have a clearly defined professional pathway. Rather than positioning uncertainty as a limitation, the curriculum emphasizes transferable technical skills, creative exploration, and sustained engagement across disciplines and communities.

Situated within art and animation, the projects are presented as a progression from classroom-based experiments focused on foundational skills to larger collaborative and community-engaged work. Across this arc, animation principles and digital media workflows, including motion graphics, projection mapping, 3D visualization, data-driven imagery, and visuals for live performance, function as shared languages connecting multiple creative and technical fields.

Within a smaller program, increased overlap between disciplines is not incidental but essential. This overlap encourages students to recognize connections across animation, design, visualization, and interactive media, reinforcing technical skills as adaptable rather than siloed. This approach supports exploration, builds confidence, and reduces pressure to prematurely specialize. It also mirrors an industry landscape in which evolving technologies enable artists to work across multiple roles and avoid narrow specialization.

The presentation features visual documentation of student outcomes, project structures, and select interdisciplinary and service-learning collaborations, paired with reflection on what worked and what didn't. Attendees will leave with practical strategies for scaffolding engagement, connecting student work to community contexts, and using institutional constraints as creative assets. This talk offers transferable approaches for digital media educators looking to unite technology, artistry, and purpose while strengthening ties between universities and the communities they serve.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → Education; Collaborative learning; •
Computing methodologies → Computer graphics; Animation.

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